



SEX & DISABILITY

NURS 280 JUNE 18, 2026



SEX & PHYSICAL DISABILITY IN CANADA

All Canadians, including youth with physical disabilities, are entitled to sexual health education in order to acquire the information and skills needed to:

- Reduce their risk of sexual and reproductive health problems;
- Increase their ability to maintain rewarding relationships;
- Achieve overall health and well-being.

Questions & Answers: Sexual Health Education for Youth with Physical Disability. PHAC 2014



SEX & DISABILITY IN CANADA

Although research suggests school-aged youth with physical disabilities are as sexual as youth without physical disabilities, peers, parents, educators and other professionals may assume they are asexual or lacking sexual interest.

Questions & Answers: Sexual Health Education for Youth with Physical Disability. PHAC 2013



GF STRONG SEXUAL HEALTH REHAB

[KEY TOPICS ▾](#)[RELATIONSHIPS ▾](#)[KIDS + PARENTING ▾](#)[RESOURCES](#)[ABOUT](#)[HOME](#)

When it comes to sex and spinal cord injury, we're all about kissing and telling.

[ABOUT US ▶](#)[I'M FEELING...](#)[CONFUSED](#)[ADVENTUROUS](#)[SHY](#)[DESIRED](#)[LUCKY](#)

SENSUAL SOLUTIONS

🌸 Celebrating 15 Years of Service! 🌸



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SPENCER WILLIAMS' COLUMN ON VICE



Watch Politics LGBTQ Drugs Opinions Photos Magazine Culture Travel NSFW



Vice Channels

Spencer Williams

STUFF



How to Navigate a Differently-Abled Relationship

An interview with Ben Mattlin, the author of 'In Sickness and In Health,' on life, his new book, and the secret to maintaining any relationship.

STUFF



Living Alone Is Awesome, Even with My Disability

Growing up with cerebral palsy, I always thought having my own apartment was an impossible dream.

SPENCER WILLIAMS / 12.27.17

SEX



I Give Disabled People Orgasms for a Living

And I'm proud of it.

SPENCER WILLIAMS / 5.18.17

BARS

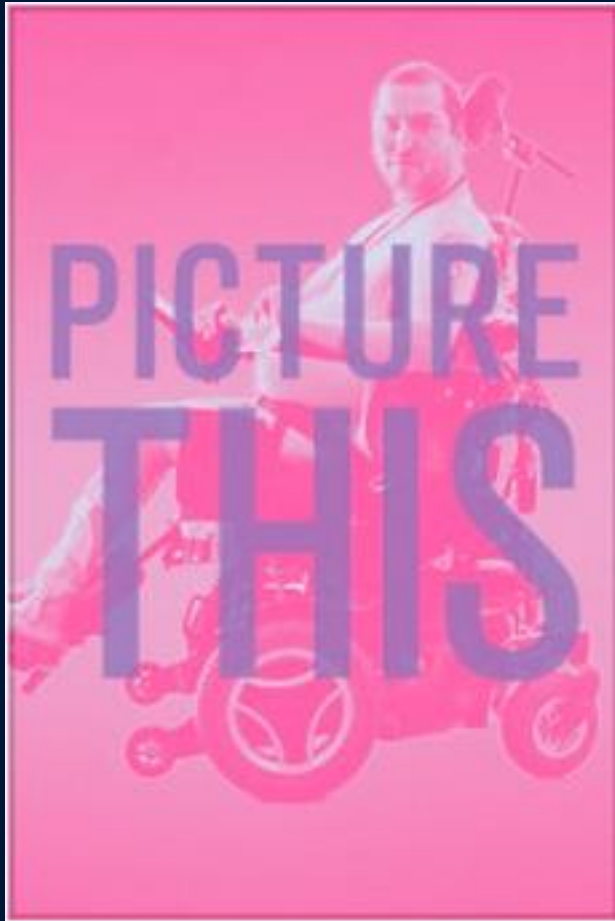


Why I Don't Like Going to Bars as a Disabled Person

From inaccessible bathrooms to weird looks, drinking with your friends at a pub isn't such a piece of cake.

SPENCER WILLIAMS / 4.5.17

THREE DOCUMENTARIES



TEACHING SEXUAL HEALTH TO PEOPLE WITH DEVELOPMENTAL DISABILITIES

"Persons with physical, cognitive, or emotional disabilities have a right to sexuality education, sexual health care, and opportunities for socializing and for sexual expression. Family, health care workers and other caregivers should receive training in understanding and supporting sexual development and behavior, comprehensive sexuality education, and related health care for individuals with disabilities."

SIECUS Report: *Sexuality Education for People with Disabilities*,
February/March 2001



BEST PRACTICES (*DAVID HINGSBURGER*)

- Empower people by giving them correct information about sex and teach them to use correct language for their own body parts
- Be certain people understand and are aware of the concept of privacy
- Teach about types of touch
- Teach about personal boundaries and when it is okay to say “no”. Often people with disabilities are taught to do as they are told but they need to know they have the right to resist when personal boundaries are crossed.
- Ensure people understand their personal rights and their choices for healthy sexuality



MORE PRACTICAL SKILLS

- Refusal skills and consent skills
- Age-appropriate affection and touching
- Practical skills for care of body, and safer sex, for example
- Offer opportunities to observe or rehearse skills





REAL TALK

HAVE HONEST
(CONVERSATIONS) ABOUT
DATING, LOVE,
RELATIONSHIPS AND SEX FOR
EVERYONE.

We are a sexual health initiative aimed at people with cognitive disabilities and their supporters. We host educational/social events where people can have open, honest conversations about dating, love, relationships, and sex. Want more info? **Download our brochure here!**

PIZZA PARTY



People with a cognitive disability meet over a casual meal to watch some Real Talk videos and participate in a conversation facilitated by a certified sexual health educator. (It's free to attend!)

Public or Private?



Public or Private?



Public or Private?



Public or Private?

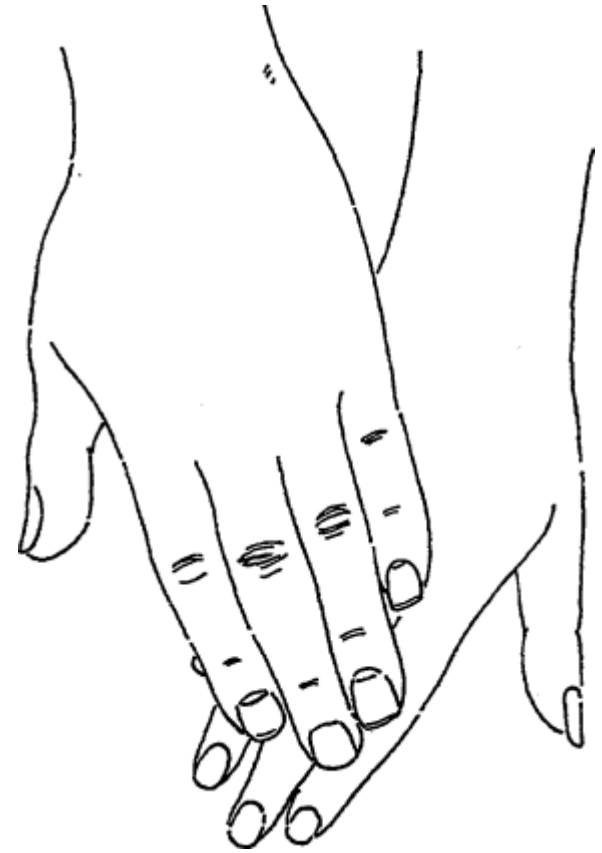


Public or Private?



Public or Private?





TASK ANALYSES / CHUNKING / SOCIAL STORIES

Washing Hands

turn on



wet hands



add soap



wash hands



rinse hands



turn off



dry hands



Going to the Toilet

pants down



pee in toilet



OR

sit on toilet



wipe



pants up



flush



wash hands





SOME DATA ABOUT DISABILITY AND SEXUAL ASSAULT

- The risk of being physically or sexually assaulted for adults with developmental disabilities is likely 4 to 10 times as high as it is for other adults (Sobsey, 1994)
- Children with any kind of disability are more than twice as likely to be sexually abused (Little, 2004)
- Regardless of age, race, ethnicity, sexual orientation or class, women with disabilities are assaulted, raped and abused at a rate more than two times greater than non-disabled women (Cusitar, 1994; Sobsey, 1994)
- Women with developmental disabilities are more likely to be re-victimized by the same person, and more than half never seek assistance with legal or treatment services (Pease & Frantz, 1994)
- Although about 80% of women and 60% of men with developmental disabilities will be sexually molested by age 18, only 3% of their attackers go to jail (Hingsburger, 2002)

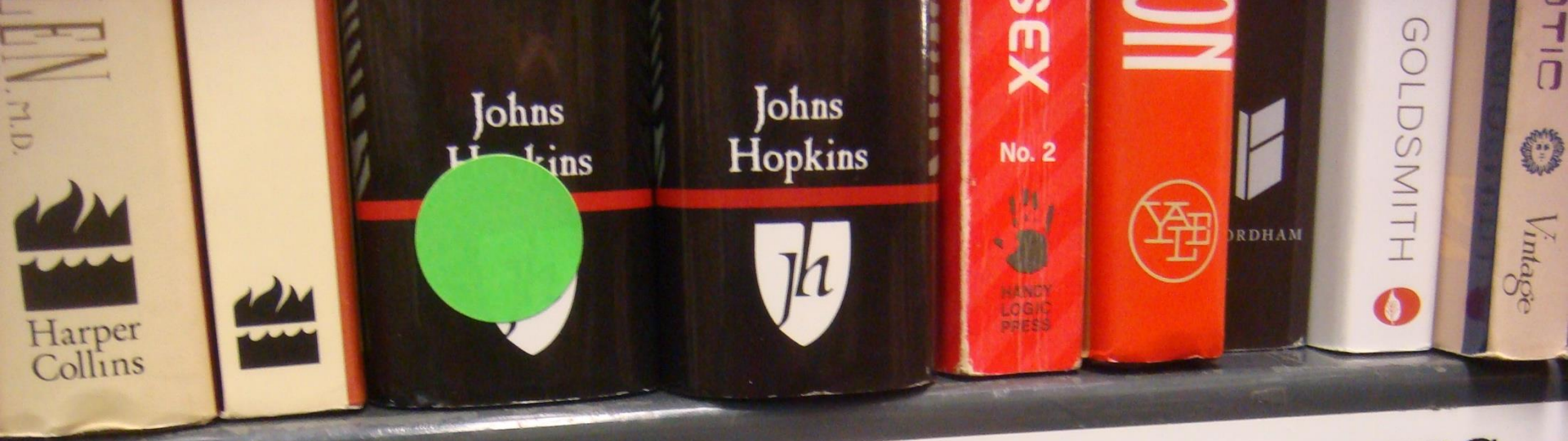


PEOPLE WITH DISABILITIES ARE MORE AT RISK OF SEXUAL ABUSE BECAUSE:

- They often need assistance with personal care and hygiene
- They may find it difficult to report abuse because of communication difficulties
- They are often taught to comply with authority which may make it harder for them to recognize abuse
- They may be targeted because of their lower cognitive functioning
- They may not be believed when they report abuse







SEXUALITY CONTINUES



THE UNIVERSITY OF BRITISH COLUMBIA

